small rocky island; the Mongols generally did not like to cross oceans, even when their prey was in sight. Instead, Kadan went back to his general.

Subotai had just dispatched a scouting party to go even farther westward: to the borders of Frederick's Holy Roman Empire itself. They got within sight of Vienna, on the edge of the empire. Rumors of the quick-moving invaders spread, terrifying all who heard. A Hungarian priest announced that the Mongols were, in fact, the Antichrist. "Tribulation long foreknown and foretold has come upon us . . . with a ferocity already described by the testimony of the Holy Scriptures," wrote a Polish Franciscan to his brethren. "They are the sword of the Lord's anger for the sins of the Christian people," mourned the Count Palatine of Saxony, in a letter to a fellow duke.[15]

It seemed that the end of days had come. And then, as quickly as the sky had clouded over, the storm blew away.

Even as Subotai's scouts were gazing at Vienna's distant spires, Ogodei Khan was dying. Before the great Mongol general could organize an attack on the Holy Roman Empire, he received the news that his old friend and master was dead. At once, he collected his troops and headed home.

Batu remained in the west, governing his conquered lands from Sarai, his new capital city on the lower Volga; his kingdom became known as the Golden Horde. But back in the Mongol heartland, a family feud had broken out over the succession to the title of Great Khan. Subotai intended to be there for the election of the next Mongol overlord.[16]

He never came west again. In Karakorum, he found the Mongol clans divided in support of Genghis Khan's grandsons; and the four years of infighting that followed brought a temporary end to Mongol conquests.